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Nobody Warned Me About This.

The perimenopause survival guide — what's
happening, and exactly what to do about it.

START HERE

You're not losing your mind. You're in perimenopause.

The 3 a.m. wide-awake. The rage that comes out of nowhere at people you love. The brain fog so bad you forget words mid-sentence and quietly panic that something is wrong with you. The anxiety, the weight that won't budge, the body that stopped feeling like yours. And the doctor who glances at your labs and says, "everything looks normal."

It is not normal — it's perimenopause, and it can start in your late 30s or 40s, up to **ten years** before your last period. Your hormones aren't gently declining; they're swinging wildly, and that chaos hits sleep, mood, memory, and your whole body. Almost no one is told this. That's why you feel blindsided and a little crazy. You're neither.

This isn't a gentle doctor's note. It's a map: name what's happening, match each symptom to what actually helps, and walk into appointments with the exact words so you stop getting dismissed.

READ THIS

"Your labs are normal" does not mean "nothing is wrong." Standard bloodwork often misses perimenopause because hormone levels fluctuate day to day. Your symptoms are the diagnosis. Trust them.

STEP 1

Is it perimenopause? The symptom check

Tick everything you've noticed in the last several months. Three or more in your late 30s–40s and perimenopause is very much on the table.

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Wide awake at 3 a.m. / broken sleep | ☐ Bloating |
| ☐ Night sweats | ☐ Crushing fatigue |
| ☐ Hot flashes | ☐ Low libido |
| ☐ Sudden rage or irritability | ☐ Vaginal dryness |
| ☐ Anxiety or dread out of nowhere | ☐ Joint aches and stiffness |
| ☐ Low mood / tearfulness | ☐ Heart palpitations |
| ☐ Brain fog, losing words | ☐ New or worse migraines |
| ☐ Forgetting things, can't focus | ☐ Thinning hair / dry skin |
| ☐ Periods changing / irregular | ☐ Itchy or crawling skin |
| ☐ Heavier or lighter bleeding | ☐ Tearful, then furious, then fine |
| ☐ Weight gain, especially belly | ☐ Feeling like a stranger in your body |

THE RELATIONSHIP COST IS REAL

The rage and brain fog don't just hurt you — they strain your marriage, your parenting, your work. This is not a character flaw or "being difficult." It's a hormone shift. Naming it protects the people you love from thinking it's about them.

STEP 2

Symptom → what actually helps

You can't out-discipline hormones, but these levers genuinely take the edge off. Match yours:

Insomnia / 3 a.m. wake-ups

Lever: cool, dark, consistent bedtime; cut alcohol and late caffeine (both wreck perimenopausal sleep); magnesium-rich foods. Ask your doctor about options if it persists.

Rage / anxiety / mood swings

Lever: this is hormonal, not a flaw. Steady blood sugar (protein every meal), daily movement, 5 slow breaths twice a day. If it's running your life, this is exactly what to raise with your doctor.

Brain fog / forgetting words

Lever: protect sleep, protein, and stress — the fog worsens with all three. Externalize memory (write everything down). It is not early dementia; it's hormones.

Weight gain / belly changes

Lever: strength training 2–3×/week + protein protect muscle and metabolism far more than cardio or cutting calories. This is the #1 lever and almost no one tells you.

Hot flashes / night sweats

Lever: track triggers (alcohol, spicy food, stress, heat), layer clothing, cool the room. Persistent ones are very treatable — bring them to your doctor.

STEP 3

The doctor script (so you're not dismissed)

Bring your ticked symptom list. Don't soften it. Ask these out loud so you leave with options, not a brush-off:

“ OPEN WITH THIS

Based on my age and these symptoms, I think this is perimenopause. I want to talk through my options, including hormone therapy.

“ ASK ABOUT HRT DIRECTLY

Am I a candidate for hormone therapy (HRT/MHT)? What are the real risks and benefits for someone like me? The research has changed — I want the current picture.

“ RULE THINGS OUT

Can we check thyroid, ferritin/iron, B12, and vitamin D too, so we're not missing something treatable?

“ IF YOU'RE DISMISSED

I hear you, but my quality of life is affected and "you're fine" isn't working for me. I'd like to explore options or a referral to a menopause specialist.

KNOW THIS GOING IN

Many GPs got almost no menopause training. If yours waves you off, that's a them-problem, not a you-problem. You are allowed to find a doctor who takes it seriously. Keep going until someone does.

STEP 4

Tell the people around you

Suffering in silence makes everything worse and lets the people you love take the rage personally. Use the words:

“ TO YOUR PARTNER

I'm going through perimenopause — my hormones are swinging and it's affecting my sleep, my mood, my body. When I snap, it's not about you. I need patience and a teammate while I figure out treatment.

“ TO YOUR KIDS (age-appropriate)

My body's going through a big change that makes me tired and short-tempered sometimes. It's not your fault, and I'm working on it.

“ AT WORK (if you need it)

I'm managing a health issue affecting my sleep and focus right now. I may need [a flexible start / fewer late meetings] for a bit.

WHERE TO GET REAL HELP

Find a certified menopause practitioner at the Menopause Society directory (menopause.org → "Find a Practitioner"). Trusted info: menopause.org and the "Balance" app/site by Dr. Louise Newson. You don't have to white-knuckle this alone.

This guide is educational, not medical advice. Make all treatment decisions with a qualified clinician.

YOU'RE NOT CRAZY

You were never crazy. You were uninformed.

Read these on the foggy, furious days. They're true:

- My symptoms are real even when my labs look "normal."
- The rage and fog are hormones, not my character.
- I'm allowed to ask for hormone therapy and a second opinion.
- This is a transition, not the end of me — and it's treatable.
- Taking care of myself through this is health, not vanity.

DO THIS WEEK

Book the appointment, bring your ticked symptom list and the HRT question, and start ONE lever from Step 2 (protein + a strength session is the highest-impact place to start). You don't have to white-knuckle a decade.

Now you have the words — and the map.

You were never crazy, broken, or "just stressed." You were in the dark about a transition half the planet goes through and no one explains. Name it, treat it, tell your people, and demand a doctor who takes it seriously. You get to feel like yourself again — and now you know how to fight for it.

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